

THE NATION-STATE

The term nation-state is generally used to describe the combination of a political state with the emotional sensibility of a collective social identity. The state is a geographic territory with its own independent government, and it must have enough size and force that it is not swallowed up by another. The nation is based on some combination of shared language, religion, history, ethnicity, future aspiration, and a sense of distinctiveness from, competition with, or antagonism toward, some other nation-state or states. Nation-states may emerge from the break-up of larger empires—which may contain several nations within themselves—or from the aggrandizement of small units into larger ones through conquest or merger. Both these processes had been

continuing in western Europe for centuries. Small units, like the region around Paris under Hugh Capet, were expanding into states, while large units, like Charlemagne's empire, were dissolving.

The nation-states had developed relatively efficient central governments that were capable of collecting taxes, keeping the peace, and raising and deploying armies and navies effectively in waging war. Their authority was generally recognized and accepted—even welcomed—by most of the people within their borders. That authority was different in different nation-states: England, France, and Portugal were monarchies; the Netherlands was ruled by a coalition of businessmen; Spain was a part of the larger Habsburg Empire.

Nation-states took an interest in the economic welfare of their people, although here too different states adopted different policies at different times, some capitalist, some mercantilist but with independent merchants, some state controlled. They engaged in external, overseas trade and commerce and, in this period of time, colonization. The development of overseas trade and colonization that we have studied in this chapter and in Chapter 13 was a large part of their transformation from small, locally governed units into nation-states. They also defined themselves by their relationship to one another—generally competitive, often hostile, sometimes belligerent.

By the mid-1700s the nation-states of western Europe had become the object of both fear and emulation. They were feared because of their economic and military powers. They could, and did, fight wars, conquer territories, create colonies, and dominate trade networks. Many societies and governments feared victimization by them. Consider, for example, the fate of the Aztecs, Inca, and other Native Americans. These fears led some states to keep these new nation-states at arm's length as long as they could. China and Japan remained essentially closed for centuries. It led still other governments to emulate them, to develop the strength to resist them even while becoming more like them. This was the response of Russia under Peter the Great.

The period we are now studying is critical to the formation of nation-states because in their competition over trade routes and colonies around the world, these nation-states defined themselves in relation to one another and in relation to the other civilizations with which they were engaging. This self-definition in terms of the "Other" is certainly not the only element in the definition of the nation-state, but it is important. Moreover, as the trade and colonization of European nation-states encountered other groupings of people around the world, both the Europeans and the peoples they encountered began to redefine themselves politically and culturally. The European nation-state evoked many different responses. In the rest of this chapter we shall consider some of the most important in this early era of European trade and colonial expansion.

RUSSIA'S EMPIRE UNDER PETER THE GREAT

At the end of the seventeenth century Russia had little direct contact with the market economies of northwestern Europe. The country was geographically remote by land, and by sea its principal ocean port was Archangel at the extreme north, on the White Sea, ice-bound for most of the year. The foreign trade that did exist was carried by foreign ships traveling Russia's great rivers, especially the Volga. Russia belonged to the Greek Orthodox branch of Christianity, so communication with the Church of Rome and its western European networks was also limited. Mongol rule had further isolated Russia culturally from western Europe, tying it more closely to Central Asia.

Russia began to take its modern form only after Ivan III (r. 1462–1505) overthrew Mongol domination in 1480. Muscovy, the territory around Moscow, became the core

of an expanding independent state. At first, Russia expanded southeastward, defeating the khanate of Astrakhan in 1556 and capturing the Volga River basin south to the Caspian Sea with its access to the silk trade of Persia. It also expanded eastward all the way to the Pacific (1649), capturing Siberia and its rich population of fur-bearing animals.

Because of its isolation and foreign rule, Russia had only a tiny urban trading class and very few big city markets. As late as 1811, only 4 percent of its population was urban. The overwhelming majority of its people lived in **serfdom**, which bound people not directly to specific owners, but to specific land and its landlords, with little possibility for economic, social, or geographic mobility. After 1675 landlords gained the right to sell serfs off the land, even to urban owners. Occasional serf uprisings, like that led by Stepan Razin (Stenka Razin; d. 1671) in 1667, were brutally suppressed, and the gulf between free persons and serfs increased.

When Peter I, the Great (r. 1682–96 as co-emperor with his half-brother; 1696–1725 as sole emperor), became sole emperor, he saw Sweden as his principal external enemy. Sweden already held Finland and the entire eastern shore of the Baltic, bottling up Russia without any Baltic port. Worse, in a crushing blow, 8000 Swedish troops defeated 40,000 Russians at the Battle of Narva in 1700. Humiliated, Peter set out to construct in Russia a powerful state based on a powerful army and navy. In 1697, traveling under an assumed name in order to evade royal protocol, Peter had embarked on a “Grand Embassy of Western Europe,” especially England and the Netherlands, but also Baltic ports and the Holy Roman Empire. He searched for allies for the wars he expected against the Turks as Russia pushed toward the Black Sea; he gathered information on the economic, cultural, and military-industrial practices of the western European powers; and for several months he even worked as a ship’s carpenter in Amsterdam.

Impressed by the strength of the western European countries, Peter invited to

Russia military experts from the West to train and lead his troops. He bought western European artillery and copied it. He established naval forces and reorganized the army along Western lines, in uniformed regiments, armed with muskets. He promoted mining, metallurgy, and textile manufacture, largely as means of supplying his troops. By 1703–4 Peter had started to build a new capital, an all-weather port and “window on the West,” in St. Petersburg on land that he conquered from Sweden. Commercially, geographically, and architecturally, he



designed St. Petersburg as a Western city. Thirty thousand died in the construction of the city from disease, drowning, or lack of food.

In 1709, when Sweden again invaded Russia, Peter was prepared. He retreated until the Swedes fell from the exhaustion of pursuing him through the severe Russian winter. Then, holding his ground at Poltava in south Russia, he defeated the remaining Swedish troops. The Swedish army was finished as an imperial force, and Russia began to seize additional Baltic possessions.

Peter's goals for Westernization were not exclusively military. He wanted Russia to be counted among the powers of Europe, and this would require cultural and economic ties as well. Peter required Western-style education for all male nobles. He established schools for their children, and sent many to study in western Europe. He demanded that aristocrats acquire the morals and tastes of Europe's elites. He made them abandon their Russian dress in favor of the clothing of western Europe, and forced the men to shave or trim their beards in the Western style. He introduced "cipher schools" for teaching basic reading and arithmetic, established a printing press, established and edited Russia's first newspaper, and funded the Academy of Sciences, which opened in 1724, a year before his death. Collectively, all these revolutionary reforms drove a wedge between the nobility and the mass of Russians.



Economically, Peter pushed for the creation of new enterprises. He built a fleet on the Baltic and encouraged exports. He organized new companies headed by groups of Russians and foreigners, and supplied them with working capital and serf laborers. He accepted the mercantilist concept of an economically strong state and saw no role for a free market in achieving it. To finance these state-organized initiatives, Peter introduced heavy taxes, which fell especially severely on the peasantry.

No democrat, Peter demanded loyalty and obedience to himself. He created a new system of administration with himself as head. He brought the Eastern Orthodox Church under state control and subordinated its clergy to his own leadership. He streamlined local and central government. He created a new "state service," including both civil and military officials, and made appointments to it completely without regard to family status, birth, or seniority. Foreigners could serve within this service, serfs could be elevated, and nobles could be demoted. All depended on performance. In 1722 he introduced a new Table of Ranks, which automatically gave noble status to officials who reached the eighth position out of fourteen. The newly elevated nobility were the chief administrators of his new policies of Westernization. These moves were revolutionary and did not survive long after Peter's death.

Peter strengthened the economic and political position of the ruling classes, the landowners, and the rising bourgeoisie while exploiting the peasantry ruthlessly. He allotted to the nobility some 175,000 serfs and 100,000 acres of land in the first half of his reign alone. Conscription, programs of forced labor, a poll tax, and indirect taxes on everything from bee-keeping to salt provoked two major uprisings in the Russian interior between 1705 and 1708. The czar suppressed them brutally. An iron-willed autocrat, Peter brought his nation into Europe and made it an important military and economic power, but millions of Russians paid a terrible price.

Peter achieved many of his goals, establishing a strong central administration, a powerful military, some commercial enterprise, international trade connections, and diplomatic contact with the nations of western Europe. He did not, however, free Russia's merchants to carry on the kinds of independent economic activity characteristic of western European commerce. And he kept the largest enterprises, like weapons

manufacture and shipping, in the hands of the state. Considered an **enlightened despot**—a ruler who advanced new concepts of intellectual inquiry and legal rights, at least for the nobility, but held on to power for himself—Peter died in 1725. Since he had killed his own son rather than permit him to sidetrack reforms, Peter was succeeded for two years by his wife and then by other family members.

In 1762 Catherine II, the Great, assumed the throne and ruled for thirty-four years. At least as despotic as Peter, Catherine won especially important victories over Poles and Turks, expanding the borders of Russia to the Black Sea. After brutally suppressing a revolt by hundreds of thousands of serfs led by Yemelyan Pugachev (1726–75), she further reduced the power of Russia's serfs.